IFAB®

THE INTERNATIONAL FOOTBALL ASSOCIATION BOARD



Glossary

The Glossary contains words/phrases which need clarification or explanation beyond the detail in the Laws and/or which are not always easily translated into other languages.

Football bodies

The IFAB – The International Football Association Board
Body composed of the four British FAs and FIFA which is responsible for the Laws of the Game worldwide. In principle, changes to the Laws may only be approved at the Annual General Meeting usually held in February or March

FIFA – Fédération Internationale de Football Association
The governing body responsible for football throughout the world

Confederation
Body responsible for football in a continent. The six confederations are AFC (Asia), CAF (Africa), Concacaf (North, Central America and Caribbean), CONMEBOL (South America), OFC (Oceania) and UEFA (Europe)

National football association
Body responsible for football in a country

Football terms

A

Abandon
To end/terminate a match before the scheduled finish

Additional time
Time allowed at the end of each half for time 'lost' because of substitutions, injuries, disciplinary action, goal celebrations etc.

Advantage
The referee allows play to continue when an offence has occurred, or a restart has been incorrectly taken and the ball is in play, if this benefits the opposing team

Assessment of injured player
Quick examination of an injury, usually by a medical person, to see if the player requires treatment

Away goals rule
Method of deciding a match/tie when both teams have scored the same number of goals; goals scored away from home count double

B

Brutality
An act which is savage, ruthless or deliberately violent

C

Careless
Any action (usually a tackle or challenge) by a player which shows a lack of care or attention for the opponent

Caution
Disciplinary sanction which results in a report to a disciplinary authority; indicated by showing a yellow card; two cautions in a match result in a player or team official being sent off

Challenge
An action when a player competes/contests with an opponent for the ball

Charge (an opponent)
Physical challenge against an opponent, usually using the shoulder and upper arm (which is kept close to the body)

Concussion substitution
A competition option that allows each team to make an extra substitution (and grants them an extra substitution opportunity, where applicable) if one of their players suffers an actual or suspected concussion
See 'Additional permanent concussion substitutions protocol'

'Cooling' break
In the interests of player welfare and safety, competition rules may allow, in certain weather conditions (high humidity and temperatures), 'cooling' breaks (usually ninety seconds to three minutes) to allow the body's temperature to fall; these are different from 'drinks' breaks

D

Deceive
Act to mislead/trick the referee into giving an incorrect decision/disciplinary sanction which benefits the deceiver and/or their team

Deliberate
An action which the player intended/meant to make; it is not a 'reflex' or unintended reaction

Direct free kick
A free kick from which a goal can be scored by kicking the ball directly into the opponents' goal without having to touch another player

Discretion
Judgment used by a referee or other match official when making a decision

Dissent
Public protest or disagreement (verbal and/or physical) with a match official's decision; punishable by a caution (yellow card)

Distract
Disturb, confuse or draw attention (usually unfairly)

'Drinks' break
Competition rules may allow 'drinks' breaks (of no more than one minute) for players to rehydrate; these are different from 'cooling' breaks

Dropped ball
The restart when play has been stopped by the referee without an offence having been committed, e.g. due to injury, a defective ball etc. (see Law 8)

E

Electronic performance and tracking system (EPTS)
System which records and analyses data about the physical and physiological performance of a player

Endanger the safety of an opponent
Put an opponent at danger or risk (of injury)

Excessive force
Using more force/energy than is necessary

Extra time
A method of trying to decide the outcome of a match involving two equal additional periods of play not exceeding 15 minutes each

F

Feinting
An action which attempts to confuse an opponent. The Laws define permitted and 'illegal' feinting

Field of play (pitch)
The playing area confined by the touchlines and goal lines and goal nets where used

G

Goal line technology (GLT)
Electronic system which immediately informs the referee when a goal has been scored i.e. the ball has wholly passed over the goal line in the goal (see Law 1 for details)

H

Holding offence
A holding offence occurs only when a player's contact with an opponent's body or equipment impedes the opponent's movement

Hybrid system
A combination of artificial and natural materials to create a playing surface which requires sunlight, water, air circulation and mowing

I

Impede
To delay, block or prevent an opponent's action or movement

Indirect free kick
A free kick from which a goal can only be scored if another player (of any team) touches the ball after it has been kicked

Intercept
To prevent a ball reaching its intended destination

K

Kick
The ball is kicked when a player makes contact with it with the foot and/or the ankle

N

Negligible
Insignificant, minimal

O

Offence
An action which breaks/violates the Laws of the Game

Offensive, insulting or abusive language/action(s)
Verbal or physical behaviour which is rude, hurtful, disrespectful; punishable by a sending-off (red card)

Outside agent
Any animal, object or structure, etc., as well as any person who is not a match official or on the team list (players, substitutes and team officials)

P

Penalise
To punish, usually by stopping play and awarding a free kick or penalty kick to the opposing team (see also Advantage)

Penalties (penalty shoot-out)
Previously 'Kicks from the penalty mark'
Method of deciding the result of a match by each team alternately taking kicks until one team has scored one more goal and both teams have taken the same number of kicks (unless during the first five kicks for each team, one team could not equal the other team's score even if they scored from all their remaining kicks)

Penalty shoot-out
See 'Penalties (penalty shoot-out)'

Play
Action by a player which makes contact with the ball

Playing distance
Distance to the ball which allows a player to touch the ball by extending the foot/leg or jumping or, for goalkeepers, jumping with arms extended. Distance depends on the physical size of the player

Q

Quick free kick
A free kick taken (with the referee's permission) very quickly after play was stopped

R

Reckless
Any action (usually a tackle or challenge) by a player which disregards (ignores) the danger to, or consequences for, the opponent

Restart
Any method of resuming play after it has been stopped

Restart position
A player's position at a restart is determined by the position of their feet or any part of their body which is touching the ground, except as outlined in Law 11 – Offside; if the player is airborne, their position is determined by the projected position of their feet if they were touching the ground

S

Sanction
Disciplinary action taken by the referee

Save
An action by a player to stop or attempt to stop the ball when it is going into or very close to the goal using any part of the body except the hands/arms (unless a goalkeeper within their own penalty area)

Semi-automated offside technology (SAOT)
Technology which immediately sends information in relation to offside positions to the video assistant referee (VAR) and, in an advanced version, also directly to the assistant referees

Sending-off
Disciplinary action when a player is required to leave the field for the remainder of the match having committed a sending-off offence (indicated by a red card); if the match has started the player cannot be replaced.
A team official may also be sent off.

Serious foul play
A tackle or challenge for the ball that endangers the safety of an opponent or uses excessive force or brutality; punishable by a sending-off (red card)

Shinguard
A piece of equipment worn to help protect a player's shin from injury. Players are responsible for wearing shinguards made of a suitable material and of an appropriate size to provide reasonable protection, and they must be covered by the socks

Shirt
A garment worn over a player's upper body as part of a team's uniform. Apart from the length of the sleeves, the shirts of all players in a team are the same, except for the goalkeeper, whose shirt distinguishes them from the other players and the match officials

Signal
Physical indication from the referee or any match official; usually involves movement of the hand or arm or flag, or use of the whistle (referee only)

Simulation
An action which creates a wrong/false impression that something has occurred when it has not (see also Deceive); committed by a player to gain an unfair advantage

Spirit of the game
The main/essential principles/ethos of football as a sport but also within a particular match (see Law 5)

Suspend
To stop a match for a period of time with the intention of eventually restarting play e.g. due to fog, heavy rain, thunderstorm, serious injury

T

Tackle
A challenge for the ball with the foot (on the ground or in the air)

Team list
Official team document usually listing the players, substitutes and team officials

Team official
Any non-player listed on the official team list e.g. coach, physiotherapist, doctor (see Technical staff)

Technical area
Defined area (in stadiums) for the team officials which includes seating (see Law 1 for details)

Technical staff
Official non-playing team members listed on the official team list e.g. coach, physiotherapist, doctor (see Team official)

Temporary dismissal
A temporary suspension from the next part of the match for a player guilty of some/all cautionable offences (depending on competition rules)

U

Undue interference
Action/influence which is unnecessary

Unsporting behaviour
Unfair action/behaviour; punishable by a caution

V

Violent conduct

An action, which is not a challenge for the ball, which uses or attempts to use excessive force or brutality against an opponent or when a player deliberately strikes someone on the head or face unless the force used is negligible

Referee terms

Match official(s)
General term for person or persons responsible for controlling a football match on behalf of a football association and/or competition under whose jurisdiction the match is played

Referee
The main match official for a match who operates on the field of play. Other match officials operate under the referee's control and direction. The referee is the final/ultimate decision-maker

Other match officials
'On-field' match officials
Competitions may appoint other match officials to assist the referee:

- **Assistant referee**
  A match official with a flag positioned on one half of each touchline to assist the referee particularly with offside situations and goal kick/corner kick/ throw-in decisions
- **Fourth official**
  A match official with responsibility for assisting the referee with both on-field and off-field matters, including overseeing the technical area, controlling substitutes etc.
- **Additional assistant referee (AAR)**
  A match official positioned on the goal line to assist the referee particularly with situations in/around the penalty area and goal/no-goal decisions

- **Reserve assistant referee**
  A match official who will replace an assistant (and, if competition rules permit, a fourth official and/or AAR) who is unable to continue and who has responsibility for assisting the referee with both on-field and off-field matters, including overseeing the technical area, controlling substitutes etc.

'Video' match officials (VMOs)

These are the VAR and AVAR who assist the referee in accordance with the Laws of the Game and the VAR protocol

- **Video assistant referee (VAR)**
  A current or former referee appointed to assist the referee by communicating information from replay footage only in relation to a 'clear and obvious error' or 'serious missed incident' in one of the reviewable categories
- **Assistant video assistant referee (AVAR)**
  A current or former referee/assistant referee appointed to assist the video assistant referee (VAR)